

Cat Sudden Aggression Reintroduction Guide — Action Checklist

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IMMEDIATE SEPARATION SETUP

- ☐ **Immediate Separation Setup:** Create two separate resource zones with food, water, litter, and familiar-smelling items like blankets from their favorite resting spots, placing cats in non-adjacent rooms when possible so proximity does not feel like ongoing threat through walls.
- ☐ **Immediate Separation Setup:** Spend 15 minutes with each cat separately sitting quietly and speaking softly, letting them approach you on their own terms while watching for defensive posture, dilated pupils, or a twitching tail tip versus a more flexible body language response.
- ☐ **Immediate Separation Setup:** Check both cats carefully for injuries by examining the neck, face, and base of the tail for puncture wounds, blood, or swelling, noting any areas where a cat flinches when you touch and scheduling a vet appointment for the next day.
- ☐ **Immediate Separation Setup:** Identify which cat appears more affected by observing who seems more frightened, more withdrawn, or more physically injured, because the more targeted cat often sets the direction for your intervention strategy.

INJURY ASSESSMENT AND VET CARE

- ☐ **Injury Assessment and Vet Care:** Look for pain-referral aggression markers including the aggressor showing pre-fight changes like decreased interest in food, increased withdrawal, or unusual irritability toward the other cat but not toward humans.
- ☐ **Injury Assessment and Vet Care:** Watch for disproportionate aggression where a normal approach from the other cat triggered an extreme reaction, or inconsistent aggression where the aggressor is fine in some rooms but not others, as these indicate a medical problem likely driving the behavior.
- ☐ **Injury Assessment and Vet Care:** Schedule a veterinary workup for both cats immediately if injuries are present or pain-referral aggression is suspected, because treating the underlying medical condition must happen before any reintroduction protocol can succeed.

- **Injury Assessment and Vet Care:** Get a complete physical examination that checks for arthritis, dental disease, hyperthyroidism, or other painful conditions that could cause one cat to lash out at a housemate who walked too close.

ROOT CAUSE INVESTIGATION

- **Root Cause Investigation:** Reconstruct the 72 hours before the fight by writing down everything that happened each day, including any guests, furniture moves, new products introduced, or changes in your own routine that could have shifted the household dynamic.
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- **Root Cause Investigation:** Look for environmental stressors like nearby construction, new neighborhood cats visible through windows, changes in household noise levels, or new objects like a new air purifier that could have overloaded one cat's stress threshold.
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- **Root Cause Investigation:** Note any pre-fight behavioral shifts in the aggressor such as reduced appetite, changed sleeping locations, increased hiding, or avoidance of previously preferred spaces, because these often indicate the cat was already overwhelmed before the fight occurred.
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- **Root Cause Investigation:** Track each cat's location, stress signals, and behavior patterns throughout the day in a notebook to identify whether the aggressive cat is guarding specific resources like a favorite window perch, food location, or litter box area.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.